

A FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY GUIDE

The Christian Spiritual Reset

*A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout,
Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith*

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FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY

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CHAPTER 3

Jesus and the Practice of Withdrawing

Chapter 2 gave you permission to withdraw without calling it selfish. Now we turn from permission to pattern: what Jesus' own practice can teach us about entering, protecting, and leaving a time of retreat. The Gospels give us more detail than most Christians realise, and the detail is instructive, because it shows a pattern rather than a formula.

A pattern, not a program

The Gospel writers record Jesus withdrawing at very different moments in his life. Read them together and a shape appears.

After a day of overwhelming demand. In **Mark 1:21–34**, Jesus spends a Sabbath in Capernaum teaching in the synagogue, confronting an unclean spirit, healing Simon's mother-in-law, and then, once the sun sets and the Sabbath ends, meeting "the whole city" gathered at the door with their sick. It had been an extraordinarily demanding day. Yet verse 35 says, "And rising very early in the morning, while it was still dark, he departed and went out to a desolate place, and there he prayed." He got up before anyone else could reach him.

In a season of loss. In **Matthew 14:1–13**, Jesus learns that John the Baptist, his relative, his forerunner, and the man who baptised

him, has been killed by Herod. Matthew then tells us that Jesus withdrew by boat to a solitary place. The text does not describe everything Jesus felt, but the timing invites us to recognise that withdrawal can be an appropriate response in a season of loss. That matters for readers carrying grief. Seeking solitude after loss is not weakness.

Before a major decision. In **Luke 6:12–13**, on the night before he chose the twelve apostles, "he went out to the mountain to pray, and all night he continued in prayer to God." Then, when day came, he made the choice. Luke is the only Gospel writer who records the all-night prayer, and he places it deliberately, right before the decision that would shape the rest of the movement. The direction came after the withdrawal, not instead of it. The lesson is not that every major decision requires an entire night without sleep. The point is that Jesus gave serious, undistracted attention to prayer before making a significant choice. During this retreat, protecting your sleep may itself be part of receiving God's care.

In a time of testing. In **Luke 4:1–2**, immediately after his baptism, Jesus is "led by the Spirit in the wilderness for forty days, being tempted by the devil." The forty days were not a restorative retreat in the usual sense. This was a unique period of fasting, testing, and preparation at the beginning of Jesus' ministry, and you are not being asked to reproduce it. Still, it reminds us that solitude does not always feel peaceful. When distractions disappear, temptation, fear, and unresolved pain may become more noticeable. Difficulty during a retreat does not necessarily mean you have made a mistake. Sometimes the quiet reveals struggles that noise had helped you avoid.

Before suffering. In **Mark 14:32–42**, on the night of his arrest, Jesus goes to Gethsemane. He takes Peter, James, and John a little further, then goes on alone, and prays one of Scripture's most

candid and costly prayers: "Abba, Father, all things are possible for you. Remove this cup from me. Yet not what I will, but what you will." He prayed it three times. His friends fell asleep. He returned to them, and then walked toward what was coming. Gethsemane belongs to Christ's unique path to the cross, and no retreat of ours compares to it. But its honesty and its surrender show us what prayer under pressure can look like.

Lay these side by side and you see that Jesus withdrew after demand, in loss, before decisions, in testing, and before suffering. There was no single mood that qualified him for solitude. He went when the work was going well and when it was about to cost him everything. If you are waiting to feel a particular way before you take this retreat, the Gospels suggest you can stop waiting.

What he did with the time

The consistent centre of Jesus' withdrawals was prayer, communion with the Father. In several places where the Gospels preserve the content of his prayers, including **Matthew 11:25–26**, **John 11:41–42**, **John 17**, and Gethsemane, his words are remarkably candid. He gives thanks, names what lies before him, intercedes for his followers, expresses what he desires, and submits himself to the Father's will.

This is worth saying clearly, because retreat culture, including much Christian retreat culture, has drifted toward wellness language. Silence, reflection, and physical rest may accompany a Christian retreat, and this guide includes all three, but they are not its ultimate centre. We do not withdraw merely to become calmer. We withdraw to become present to God. Everything else in these pages serves that.

The Gospels do not describe elaborate arrangements. They repeatedly show Jesus seeking ordinary, solitary places, a hillside, a garden, a boat, the far side of a lake, where he could pray without the immediate pressure of the crowd. You do not need a retreat centre. You need a place where interruptions can be reduced and where you can give sustained attention to God.

When the withdrawal is interrupted

Here is the part that will encourage anyone whose life does not cooperate with quiet.

Jesus' times of solitude were interrupted repeatedly. In **Mark 1:36–37**, Simon and the others go looking for him in the dark and find him with the words, "Everyone is looking for you." In **Matthew 14:13–14**, the crowds hear where his boat is heading and walk around the lake on foot, so that when he lands, "he saw a great crowd, and he had compassion on them and healed their sick." That evening, after feeding five thousand, **Matthew 14:23** says he "went up on the mountain by himself to pray." He got his time alone. It just came later than the story first suggested.

Two things to take from this. First, do everything you can to protect your retreat, and a later chapter will show you how. Second, an interruption does not automatically ruin your retreat. Respond to genuine needs, return to the quiet when possible, and reschedule what you cannot complete. Even if circumstances prevent you from finishing, the time you gave to God was not wasted.

At the same time, compassion does not require you to respond immediately to every notification, request, or preference. Jesus responded to people in need, but he did not surrender his life to every demand made upon him. Learning the difference between a

genuine need and an avoidable distraction is part of what this retreat will teach you.

He did not always go entirely alone

One more detail. Jesus often prayed alone, but on at least two especially significant occasions, the Transfiguration in **Luke 9:28–36** and Gethsemane, he brought Peter, James, and John with him. They were imperfect companions. At the Transfiguration they struggled with sleep, and in Gethsemane they failed to remain watchful during his anguish. Yet Jesus still allowed them to accompany him, and they became witnesses to moments they would never forget.

Jesus sometimes withdrew completely alone and sometimes brought trusted disciples nearby. His example leaves room for both private solitude and supported retreat. Solitude with God is essential; unhealthy isolation from people is not the goal. This is why Part Four includes formats for couples, small groups, and churches, and why even the personal version of this retreat will ask you to tell at least one person what you are doing. Afterwards, speak with someone about what became clear through Scripture, prayer, silence, and honest reflection, and test any significant impression against Scripture, the character of Christ, wise counsel, and the responsibilities God has already entrusted to you. We will return to that testing in Part Five.

More than an example

Jesus is not merely the example behind this retreat. He is the one who invites you into it. You are not trying to reproduce his life through discipline alone. You are responding to the living Christ who says, "Come to me," and who meets tired people with grace. The pattern in this chapter tells you what the days may look like. The person tells you who is waiting in them.

What this means for your three days

The structure of this retreat follows the shape you have just seen. You will begin as Jesus did after Capernaum, by getting away from the noise and simply being present before God. You will be given room, as he took after John's death, to grieve and release what you are carrying. You will spend time listening, as he did on the mountain before choosing the twelve, before you make any decisions about direction. And you will be asked to return, as he always did, to the people and the work you left, with a rhythm that can sustain you.

None of this is original. It is simply an attempt to let the way Jesus lived shape the way you rest.

Before you turn the page

1. Of the five moments listed above, which one is closest to where you are right now: after demand, in loss, before a decision, in a season of testing, or facing something hard? Write a sentence about why.
2. Jesus told the Father exactly what he wanted in Gethsemane. When did you last pray a prayer that honest? What stops you?
3. Who is one trustworthy person you could tell about this retreat? If no one comes to mind, what pastor, counsellor, mature believer, or supportive community could you begin approaching?
4. What would help you reduce avoidable interruptions without becoming anxious or resentful when a genuine need arises?